

Understanding India - Exam Preparation Notes

Weeks 10 & 11 | Comprehensive Study Guide

Week 10: Orientalism, Prejudice, Stereotype, Xenophobia

Day 1: Orientalism, Prejudice, Stereotype, Xenophobia

Key Vocabulary

- **Ebullition:** A sudden outburst of emotion or violence.
- **Proclivity:** A natural or habitual inclination or tendency.
- **Inchoate:** Just begun and not fully formed or developed.
- **Recalcitrant:** Stubbornly resistant to authority or control.
- **Antediluvian:** Extremely old-fashioned; outdated.
- **Circumspect:** Cautious and unwilling to take risks; prudent.
- **Obfuscate:** To confuse or bewilder.
- **Effrontery:** Insolent or impertinent behaviour; boldness.

1. Defining Orientalism

Edward Said's Concept (1978): Orientalism refers to a way of thinking about "the East" (mainly Asia, Middle East, North Africa) that frames these regions as exotic, backward, and mysterious. It is not just a study but a *style of thought* based on an ontological and epistemological distinction made between "the Orient" and "the Occident."

2. The Orient vs. Occident Division

- **The West (Occident):** Defined itself as civilized, progressive, rational, and superior.
- **The East (Orient):** Depicted as primitive, static, irrational, and inferior.
- **Function:** This binary created an "us vs. them" mentality that justified colonial control, suggesting the East needed Western "guidance."

3. Why Said Wrote Orientalism

Edward Said, a Palestinian-American, observed consistent misrepresentation of Eastern cultures in Western media. He aimed to challenge stereotypes, show their real-world impact on international relations/policy, and demonstrate how knowledge and power are linked.

4. Orientalism in Art and Literature

Western artists (e.g., painters, novelists) depicted the East through an exotic lens—deserts, harems, snake charmers. These portrayals simplified complex cultures into a single "strange" narrative, reinforcing the idea of the East as fundamentally different.

5. Orientalism and Colonialism

Orientalism provided the **ideological foundation** for colonialism. By framing the East as "weak" and "decadent," European powers (Britain, France) justified conquest as a "civilizing mission." Knowledge production (ethnography, mapping) was a form of power.

6. Key Concepts with India-Specific Context

- **Ethnocentrism:** Judging other cultures by one's own standards.
Example: Western media calling Indian festivals "environmentally irresponsible" without critiquing their own consumption patterns; viewing Indian democracy only through Western liberal lenses.
- **Prejudice:** Preconceived negative judgments.
Example: Anti-outsourcing rhetoric in the US/UK accusing India of "stealing jobs"; biases about India's technological rise.
- **Stereotype:** Simplistic, fixed ideas.
Example: India as a land of "mystics and gurus" or purely "poverty-stricken" (e.g., *Slumdog Millionaire*), ignoring its middle class and tech sectors.
- **Xenophobia:** Hostility toward foreign influence/people.
Example: Hate crimes against Indian immigrants abroad; restrictive visa policies targeting Indian tech workers due to fear of competition.

7. Modern Orientalism & Impact

Neo-Orientalism: Continues in modern media (e.g., films portraying Easterners as terrorists or villains). It affects India's global image by overshadowing economic progress with narratives of poverty or exoticism.

Day 2: Neo-Orientalism: Reporting Caste & Secularism

Key Terms

- **Neo-Orientalism:** Modern form of Orientalism framing Eastern societies through Western perspectives, often using progressive labels to recycle colonial tropes.

- **Narrative Framing:** How events are presented to influence interpretation.
- **Social Stratification:** Hierarchical arrangement of groups in society.

1. Neo-Orientalism Definition & Traits

Differs from classical Orientalism by being embedded in academia, think-tanks, and tech platforms. It often frames caste and secularism as "immutable pathologies" of India. It relies on selective sourcing and NGO narratives that align with Western geopolitical interests.

2. Secularism in the Indian Context

- **Constitutional Definition:** Distinct from Western *laïcité* (strict separation). Articles 25-28 guarantee religious freedom but allow state intervention for reform.
- **S.R. Bommai Case (1994):** Supreme Court affirmed secularism as part of the Constitution's basic structure.
- **Practice:** "Principled distance"—the state engages with all religions to ensure equality (e.g., managing temples, funding minority schools). It protects *pluralism*, not homogeneity.

3. Historical Roots of Caste

- **Ancient Texts:** Varna system in *Rig Veda* (Purusha Sukta) and *Manusmriti*. Originally more fluid.
- **Colonial Shift:** British census and administration *codified* and *rigidified* these identities for governance.
- **Media Distortion:** Global media often omits the history of reform (Bhakti movement) and presents caste as an "unchanging essence" of Hinduism.

4. Giddens' Structuration Theory

Anthony Giddens (1984) argued that structure enables and constrains agency. Applied here: Media acts as both structure (institution) and agent (shaping perception). Western reporting constrains how India is viewed; India's digital diplomacy attempts to reshape this structure.

5. Media Bias & Narrative Control (Upadhyay 2024)

Western media drives global narratives for its own purposes. It amplifies minority grievances while ignoring others (e.g., Kashmiri Pandits). Framing of CAA protests often lacked constitutional context. India needs to become the "narrator of its own story."

6. Digital & AI Dimensions

- **Digital Neo-Orientalism:** Social media algorithms can reinforce colonial binaries ("oppressor vs. oppressed") without nuance.

- **AI Bias:** Text-to-image AI generators often default to stereotypes (e.g., high-caste = wealthy/religious; low-caste = poverty/protest) due to Western-dominated training data.
- **Digital Divide:** Caste correlates with internet access. Government programs (BharatNet, e-Shram) aim to bridge this, but "atrocities-only" reporting obscures these efforts.

7. Subaltern Conflicts

Secular Sectarianism (Ajay Gudavarthy): Challenges the simple binary of "Upper Caste vs. Lower Caste" by highlighting intra-group conflicts among subalterns (e.g., Dalit vs. OBC competition). Media rarely captures this complexity.

8. CoHNA's Caste Awareness Study

Found that most Americans have a poor understanding of caste (believe in only 4 castes, can't identify it). Warns against institutionalizing caste laws in the US based on anecdotal evidence, which could lead to profiling of Indian-Americans.

9. Case Study: Kashmiri Pandits

The 1990 exodus (ethnic cleansing) of Kashmiri Hindus is often underreported or framed merely as "migration" by Western media, illustrating a "hierarchy of sympathy" in Neo-Orientalist reporting.

10. Cultural Sovereignty & Saffronisation

Cultural Sovereignty: India asserting its identity as a "civilizational state" rather than just a post-colonial one (e.g., NEP 2020 integrating Indian Knowledge Systems).

"Saffronisation": A pejorative term used by critics/media to describe the inclusion of Hindu contributions in curriculum. Defenders view it as "decolonizing" history.

Week 10 Practice Questions

1. Who is the author of the seminal book "Orientalism" (1978)?

- Bernard Cohn
- Edward Said
- Nicholas Dirks
- Anthony Giddens

2. Which term refers to the "West" in the binary created by Orientalism?

- The Orient
- The Subaltern

- c. The Occident
- d. The Global South

3. What was the primary ideological function of Orientalism during the 19th century?

- a. To promote cultural exchange
- b. To justify colonial rule as a "civilizing mission"
- c. To study Eastern languages scientifically
- d. To adopt Eastern religious practices

4. "Ebullition" is best defined as:

- a. A slow and steady growth
- b. A sudden outburst of emotion or violence
- c. A calculated political move
- d. A state of deep meditation

5. Judging other cultures solely by the values and standards of one's own culture is called:

- a. Xenophobia
- b. Orientalism
- c. Ethnocentrism
- d. Stereotyping

6. Which Supreme Court case affirmed secularism as part of the "basic structure" of the Indian Constitution?

- a. Kesavananda Bharati case
- b. S.R. Bommai case (1994)
- c. Shah Bano case
- d. Golaknath case

7. How does Indian secularism differ from Western "laïcité"?

- a. It mandates a state religion
- b. It allows absolutely no state intervention in religion
- c. It follows "principled distance" and allows intervention for reform
- d. It is hostile toward all religious practices

8. The term "Recalcitrant" means:

- a. Eager to please
- b. Stubbornly resistant to authority
- c. Highly intelligent
- d. New and unformed

9. According to Upadhyay (2024), what is a major flaw in Western media narratives about India?

- a. They are too focused on economic growth
- b. They amplify minority grievances while ignoring others like Kashmiri Pandits
- c. They are overly supportive of the current government
- d. They focus too much on sports

10. What theory by Anthony Giddens is applied to understand media as both structure and agent?

- a. Post-structuralism
- b. Structuration Theory
- c. Critical Race Theory
- d. Dependency Theory

11. What did CoHNA's study reveal about American understanding of caste?

- a. Most Americans are experts on the subject
- b. It is deeply understood in high schools
- c. It is largely based on anecdotal data and poor understanding
- d. It is irrelevant to policy making

12. The term "Saffronisation" is often used in Western media to criticize:

- a. Agricultural policies in Kashmir
- b. The integration of Hindu contributions into Indian curriculum
- c. The use of solar energy
- d. The color of currency notes

13. Which of the following is an example of "Neo-Orientalism" in AI?

- a. AI generating code faster than humans
- b. Text-to-image generators defaulting to caste stereotypes (e.g., Dalits in poverty)
- c. AI being used for weather forecasting
- d. Voice assistants having Indian accents

14. "Obfuscate" means to:

- a. Clarify completely
- b. Confuse or bewilder
- c. Destroy physically
- d. Build up

15. The depiction of the East as "static" and the West as "progressive" is a hallmark of:

- a. Globalization
- b. Orientalist discourse
- c. Multiculturalism
- d. Secularism

16. Which government initiative aims to bridge the digital divide in rural India?

- a. Make in India
- b. BharatNet
- c. Swachh Bharat
- d. Ayushman Bharat

17. "Effrontery" refers to:

- a. Polite behavior
- b. Insolent or impertinent behavior; boldness
- c. A front-facing building
- d. Cowardice

18. What is "Narrative Framing"?

- a. Putting a picture in a frame
- b. The way events are presented to influence interpretation

- c. Writing fiction novels
- d. Recording history objectively

19. Which term describes the 1990 displacement of Kashmiri Hindus?

- a. Voluntary migration
- b. Economic relocation
- c. Exodus/Ethnic cleansing
- d. Cultural exchange

20. "Inchoate" means:

- a. Fully developed
- b. Chaotic
- c. Just begun and not fully formed
- d. Ancient

21. Who argued that caste as a "fact of Indian society" was largely constructed through colonial knowledge production?

- a. Mahatma Gandhi
- b. Nicholas Dirks
- c. Jawaharlal Nehru
- d. Amartya Sen

22. What does "Proclivity" mean?

- a. A steep slope
- b. A natural or habitual inclination
- c. A legal prohibition
- d. A type of activity

23. Which articles of the Indian Constitution guarantee religious freedom?

- a. Articles 14-18
- b. Articles 25-28
- c. Articles 370-371
- d. Articles 51A

24. The term "Antediluvian" is used to describe something that is:

- a. Related to floods
- b. Extremely modern
- c. Extremely old-fashioned or outdated
- d. Anti-democratic

25. "Circumspect" is best defined as:

- a. Walking in circles
- b. Cautious and unwilling to take risks
- c. Looking around
- d. Bold and adventurous

26. Which concept breaks the binary of "oppressor vs. oppressed" by highlighting conflicts within marginalized groups?

- a. Intersectionality
- b. Secular Sectarianism
- c. Neo-Marxism
- d. Post-Colonialism

27. "Xenophobia" refers to:

- a. Fear of enclosed spaces
- b. Fear or dislike of people from other nations/cultures
- c. Love for foreign goods
- d. Fear of heights

28. Which of the following is an example of "Prejudice" mentioned in the notes?

- a. Preferring Indian food over Italian
- b. Anti-outsourcing rhetoric accusing India of "stealing jobs"
- c. Studying Indian history
- d. Visiting India for tourism

29. The "Kashi Tamil Sangamam" project is an example of:

- a. Saffronisation
- b. Cultural Diplomacy and Civilizational Integration
- c. Economic zoning

d. Military alliance

30. What is the central argument regarding "India-origin narratives"?

- a. They should be ignored
- b. They are only for domestic consumption
- c. There is a need for India to become the narrator of its own story in global knowledge production
- d. They are already dominant in Western media

Answer Key: Week 10

1. b	2. c	3. b	4. b	5. c
6. b	7. c	8. b	9. b	10. b
11. c	12. b	13. b	14. b	15. b
16. b	17. b	18. b	19. c	20. c
21. b	22. b	23. b	24. c	25. b
26. b	27. b	28. b	29. b	30. c

Week 11: Caste, Colonialism, Jaati and Varna

Day 1: Caste, Colonialism, Jaati and Varna

Key Terms

- **Ethnography:** Systematic study and documentation of peoples/cultures; used by colonial administrators to classify groups.
- **Census:** Government survey recording demographic data; used by British to categorize caste.
- **Social Hierarchy:** Arrangement of groups in ranked order.
- **Endogamy:** Practice of marrying within a specific community (central to Jaati).

- **Civilisation-Nation:** 'Bharat that is India' is seen as a civilisation-nation governing itself via an evolutionary state, not just a post-WWII "nation-state."

1. Context: WWII & End of Empire (1940-50)

Britain emerged from WWII economically exhausted and indebted to the USA. Moral contradictions (fighting fascism while holding colonies) and the rise of nationalism (war veterans) made the empire unsustainable. This period marked the transition from "British Raj" to independent nation-states.

2. Definitions: Caste, Varna, Jaati

- **Caste:** Often a colonial construct mixing Varna and Jaati; hereditary, endogamous.
- **Varna:** Theoretical, scriptural four-fold classification (Brahmin, Kshatriya, Vaishya, Shudra). Originally spiritual/occupational, sometimes fluid.
 - *Source:* **Purusha Sukta** (Rig Veda) describes society emerging from the cosmic being's body.
- **Jaati:** The *lived reality*. Thousands of localized, endogamous groups based on occupation, region, and kinship. This was the primary identity for most people.

3. Colonial Invention of Caste

Nicholas Dirks (2001): Argues that "Caste" as a rigid, all-encompassing system was largely a product of colonial rule ("Castes of Mind").

Bernard Cohn: Highlighted how colonial "knowledge production" (census, ethnography) transformed fluid social identities into fixed, racialized administrative categories.

4. The Colonial Census (Riskley, 1901)

H.H. Risley: The 1901 Census Commissioner who equated caste with racial identity. He formalized hierarchy, flattening local variations into rigid categories based on Brahminical texts, often distorting lived realities.

5. Legal & Social Transformations

- **Codification:** Colonial courts used caste for personal laws (marriage, inheritance), making it legally binding.
- **Criminal Tribes Act:** Labelled entire nomadic groups as "born criminals," subjecting them to surveillance.
- **Land & Labor:** Revenue settlements dispossessed small farmers. Indentured labor systems (e.g., to Mauritius/Caribbean) heavily recruited lower castes.

6. Gender and Caste

Caste purity was often tied to women's chastity (endogamy). Lower-caste women faced the "double burden" of caste and gender discrimination (sexual violence, workplace exploitation). Colonial laws often reinforced patriarchal control.

7. Partition (1947-48) & Territory

Creation of India and Pakistan (West & East). Loss of civilizational territories (Sindh, West Punjab, parts of Bengal). Contemporary India is a *portion* of its historical civilizational expanse (which once influenced SE Asia via Cholas, Guptas).

8. Anti-Caste Movements

- **Jyotiba Phule:** Satyashodhak Samaj (1873) in Maharashtra; fought Brahminical dominance.
- **Narayana Guru:** Kerala; emphasized spiritual equality ("One Caste, One Religion, One God").
- **Periyar (E.V. Ramasamy):** Self-Respect Movement (Tamil Nadu); critiqued religious orthodoxy and caste privilege.
- **Pandita Ramabai:** Focused on women's rights and education.

9. Legal Safeguards in Independent India

- **Article 17:** Abolished "Untouchability."
- **SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989:** Penalizes violence and humiliation against Dalits/Adivasis.
- **Reservations:** Affirmative action for SCs, STs, and later OBCs to address historical injustice.

10. Cultural Neocolonialism

Dirks notes that colonialism left a legacy where Indians view their own society through Western concepts (e.g., "Caste" as the defining feature). The "Deracinated Elite" (Macaulay's children) often perpetuate these views.

Technological Lesson: Need to learn innovation from the West (like Japan/China) for defense/economy while retaining cultural roots.

Week 11 Practice Questions

1. Which term describes the systematic study used by colonial administrators to classify Indian social groups?

- a. Demography
- b. Ethnography
- c. Cartography

d. Theology

2. The "Purusha Sukta," which describes the origin of the Varnas, is found in which text?

- a. Manusmriti
- b. Rig Veda
- c. Atharva Veda
- d. Upanishads

3. Who led the 1901 Census that attempted to equate caste with race?

- a. Lord Macaulay
- b. H.H. Risley
- c. William Jones
- d. Lord Curzon

4. Which social unit represents the concrete, "lived experience" of caste (endogamous, occupational)?

- a. Varna
- b. Gotra
- c. Jaati
- d. Kula

5. Nicholas Dirks' book "Castes of Mind" argues that:

- a. Caste is an eternal, unchanging Hindu reality
- b. Caste was significantly shaped and rigidified by colonial rule
- c. Caste did not exist before the British
- d. Caste is purely an economic class system

6. Which Article of the Indian Constitution abolished "Untouchability"?

- a. Article 14
- b. Article 17
- c. Article 21
- d. Article 370

7. The "Self-Respect Movement" in Tamil Nadu was led by:

- a. Jyotiba Phule
- b. B.R. Ambedkar
- c. Periyar (E.V. Ramasamy)
- d. Narayana Guru

8. What is "Endogamy"?

- a. The practice of marrying outside one's group
- b. The practice of marrying within a specific community or caste
- c. The practice of having multiple spouses
- d. The practice of celibacy

9. Which colonial act labeled entire nomadic communities as "born criminals"?

- a. The Rowlatt Act
- b. The Criminal Tribes Act
- c. The Vernacular Press Act
- d. The Ilbert Bill

10. Jyotiba Phule founded which organization to fight Brahminical dominance?

- a. Brahmo Samaj
- b. Arya Samaj
- c. Satyashodhak Samaj
- d. Prarthana Samaj

11. According to the notes, "Bharat that is India" is best described as:

- a. A mere nation-state created in 1947
- b. A British dominion
- c. A civilisation-nation
- d. A secular federation only

12. What was a major economic consequence of WWII for Britain?

- a. It became the world's richest nation
- b. It emerged heavily indebted, especially to the USA
- c. It gained more colonies

d. It paid off all its debts

13. Which region was NOT lost by India during the 1947 Partition?

- a. West Punjab
- b. Sindh
- c. East Bengal
- d. Travancore

14. Bernard Cohn is known for emphasizing:

- a. The economic benefits of colonialism
- b. The role of colonial "knowledge" (census, law) as a form of power
- c. The military strategies of the British
- d. The architectural history of Delhi

15. The SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act was enacted in:

- a. 1947
- b. 1950
- c. 1989
- d. 2000

16. Which varna is associated with "rulers and warriors" in the theoretical model?

- a. Brahmin
- b. Kshatriya
- c. Vaishya
- d. Shudra

17. Before colonial intervention, caste identities were often:

- a. Fixed and unchangeable
- b. Fluid, situational, and intertwined with region/kinship
- c. Non-existent
- d. Identical to the British class system

18. Who propounded the slogan "One Caste, One Religion, One God for Man"?

- a. Swami Vivekananda

- b. Narayana Guru
- c. Raja Ram Mohan Roy
- d. Dayanand Saraswati

19. The "Ethnographic State" refers to:

- a. A state governed by anthropologists
- b. The colonial state's obsession with classifying and documenting its subjects
- c. A tribal kingdom
- d. A modern democratic state

20. Which term refers to the "governing apparatus established by the British in India"?

- a. Colonial Administration
- b. Feudal System
- c. Panchayati Raj
- d. The Mughal Court

21. What does the "Deracinated Elite" refer to in the context of colonial legacy?

- a. Farmers who lost their land
- b. Indians culturally disconnected from their roots due to Westernized education
- c. British officers born in India
- d. Nomadic tribes

22. Which ancient text codified rules around purity and occupation, often criticized for rigidity?

- a. Rig Veda
- b. Manusmriti
- c. Ramayana
- d. Arthashastra

23. Plantation labor in colonies like Mauritius primarily recruited from:

- a. The Brahmin community

- b. The Kshatriya aristocracy
- c. Lower-caste and marginalized communities
- d. British convicts

24. Which of the following was NOT a factor in the "Sun Setting" on the British Empire?

- a. Economic exhaustion after WWII
- b. Rise of the USA as a superpower
- c. Rise of nationalism in colonies
- d. British desire to expand further

25. Pandita Ramabai is best known for her activism in:

- a. Armed revolution
- b. Women's rights and education
- c. Industrial labor unions
- d. Language politics

26. How did the British census affect the Jaati system?

- a. It accurately recorded every detail
- b. It flattened local variations into rigid, competing hierarchies
- c. It abolished the system entirely
- d. It had no effect

27. What is "Macaulay's Minute" associated with?

- a. Railways construction
- b. Introduction of English education to create a class of interpreters
- c. Military reform
- d. Land revenue systems

28. The practice of "Sati" and widowhood restrictions disproportionately affected:

- a. Men
- b. Women, often tied to caste purity
- c. British women
- d. Children only

29. Which of the following represents the "territory in which inhabitants share a common culture"?

- a. State
- b. Nation
- c. Government
- d. Corporation

30. "Cultural Neocolonisation" implies:

- a. Physical re-occupation by colonial powers
- b. Continued dominance of colonial ways of thinking and knowledge systems
- c. Revival of ancient Indian culture
- d. Colonization of new lands by India

Answer Key: Week 11

1. b	2. b	3. b	4. c	5. b
6. b	7. c	8. b	9. b	10. c
11. c	12. b	13. d	14. b	15. c
16. b	17. b	18. b	19. b	20. a
21. b	22. b	23. c	24. d	25. b
26. b	27. b	28. b	29. b	30. b